We're building *a relationship* where we _____

Two people. A pen each. About thirty minutes at the kitchen table.

Most couples have never written down what their marriage is built on. Not because they don't love each other — because nobody ever asked them to. This is the asking.

Print two copies of page three, or print the whole thing once — there's a page for each of you.

One rule

> *You each write alone first, and you don't read each other's page until you're both finished.*

This is the whole mechanic. If one of you writes first and reads it aloud, the other person stops answering the question and starts responding to an answer. You'd end up with one person's page, co-signed.

How it goes

1. **Seven minutes, alone**
   Fill in the blank as many times as you can. Don't filter, don't polish, don't worry about repeating yourself. Quantity first.

2. **Star five**
   Go back through your own list and mark the five that feel most true. Not the most impressive — the most true.

3. **Read them to each other**
   Alternate, one line at a time. Don't respond yet. Just let them land.

4. **Choose together**
   Pick three to five you both want to stand behind, and write them on the last page.

If you get stuck

Try the sentence against a narrower part of your life. You don't have to use these — they're just for unsticking.

When things are hard, we…

With money, we…

In front of other people, we…

With our kids, we…

When we're apart, we…

On an ordinary Tuesday, we…

Your page

Name _____

As many as you can. Don't filter. When you're done, fill in the circle beside the five that feel most true.

- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____

Your page

Name _____

As many as you can. Don't filter. When you're done, fill in the circle beside the five that feel most true.

- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____
- ○ *We're building a relationship where we* _____

Now compare

Read your circled five aloud, alternating, one line at a time. Don't respond, don't explain, don't defend. Get through all ten first. Then talk.

Which ones did you both write?

These are your foundation. You already agree and didn't know it.

Which one of theirs surprised you?

Not the ones you liked — the ones you didn't see coming.

Which one do you want to push back on?

A difference here isn't a problem. It's the most useful thing on this page.

When you're ready, turn the page.

What we're building

Three to five you both want to stand behind. In your handwriting, not a summary of the conversation.

01 *We're building a relationship where we* _____

02 *We're building a relationship where we* _____

03 *We're building a relationship where we* _____

04 *We're building a relationship where we* _____

05 *We're building a relationship where we* _____

SIGNED

SIGNED

DATE

Put this somewhere you'll find it again in a year.

Three questions, if you're willing

I don't want to know what you wrote. That's yours, and it should stay that way — it's the whole idea behind what I'm building. What I want to know is how the exercise itself went.

Where did you get stuck?

What did you wish you had help with — a prompt, an example, someone asking a better question?

Would you do this again in a year? Why or why not?

Reply to the email this came in on, or tell me on the call. Either is fine.

Thank you — Clark